



before publication. The Defiant Beauty issue has now sold out. In an interview with magCulture, Rhona admitted:

*'We've had to work smart and reach out to our community and readers, which we did through a fundraiser that saw us raise 3k on pre-orders of the issue, so I am feeling the most sanguine I have in about a year.'*¹⁶

THIIIRD Intersect Events, such as **Not Another Diversity Panel** at Tate Modern or **Reclaiming the Narrative Panel** at The Photographer's Gallery, provide further platforms to draw attention to the magazine, sell the current issue in their bookshops and to invite the community to join the event. The web magazine and social media publicise these events, for example in Summer 2023, the Swim N' Cook Out or the Sports Days events in combination with Black Pride and Issue #6 'BODY MOVEMENTS'.

Theoretical perspective

Cultural Industries – David Hesmondhalgh

Hesmondhalgh states large cultural industry companies try to minimise risk and maximise audiences through vertical and horizontal integration by formatting their cultural products. As an independent magazine, owned and run by a small team of passionate creatives, THIIIRD is the opposite. It doesn't follow a formula or repeat a set of genre conventions; it celebrates diversity, difference and disparate voices. It doesn't have the massive financial backing of a large conglomerate, and it doesn't seek to increase profits through advertising revenue. You could argue that in the past, mainstream consumerist magazine publishers exaggerated the opposites of binary gender characteristics to 'foster and maintain a cult of femininity'¹⁷ (or masculinity) for commercial gain. They wanted to persuade their readers to buy the products advertised in the magazine to belong, to be a better

'man' or better 'woman' (however the magazine constructed them). As an activist fashion magazine, THIIIRD deliberately steps over those boundaries into a third, different, 'queer' space of more complex, individual identities, thus embracing another, perhaps more relevant, 'shared belonging'¹⁸, for all of us. Hesmondhalgh states advertising encroaches upon every aspect of our online experience, yet there is little advertising in THIIIRD. Of course, they are always looking for partnerships to help finance their operation, there is some advertorial content, and more advertising may feature in future. However, it is a risky business for THIIIRD, who invest their time, creativity and personal savings because they believe in THIIIRD as a cultural hub for people to come together and bring about positive social change.

THIIIRD illustrates Hesmondhalgh's idea of democratisation and the radical potential of the internet. Rhona and her team saw a gap in the market for people like themselves, and so set up their own media forms. But it has not '*been contained to some extent by its partial incorporation into a large, profit-orientated set of cultural industries.*'¹⁹ They may collaborate with a major brand on a social project, or a fashion label on a niche line, but they need to be resourceful, seeking opportunities and responding when the contracts are offered. They may work in synergy with partners to collaborate with other independent media forms or with traditional cultural institutions, such as art galleries. As a cultural hub, they must be agile and alert to communicate what is happening at the time. You could argue that the THIIIRD team are examples of Hesmondhalgh's 'digital optimists'.

¹⁶ <https://magculture.com/blogs/journal/rhona-thiiird>

¹⁷ Marjorie Ferguson, *Forever Feminine: Women's Magazines and the Cult of Femininity* (1985)

¹⁸ Gilroy's term
¹⁹ David Hesmondhalgh, *The Cultural Industries*, (2012), p.2